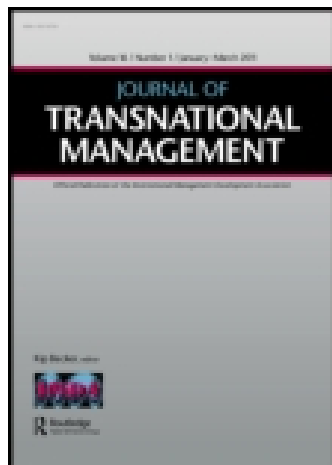


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Should Consumers Be in Love With Brands?: An Investigation Into the Influence That Specific Consumer-Brand Relationships Have on the Quality of the Bonds That Consumers Develop With Brands

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Should Consumers Be in Love With Brands?: An Investigation Into the Influence That Specific Consumer-Brand Relationships Have on the Quality of the Bonds That Consumers Develop With Brands

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This research investigates the influence that specific consumer-brand relationships have on the quality of the bonds that consumers develop with brands. This is important since disasters in the brand-consumer relationship will cause different consumer responses dependent on whether the relationship is built on a passion or intimacy-loyalty bond. Consumer-brand relationships were studied according to the interpersonal relationship theory. A SEM analysis, involving a sample of eight known brands of different product categories gave support to the theory. Results suggested that brand relationships of Intimacy-Loyalty influenced relationship strength in an indirect way through partner quality inferences and that these relationships might hold up better under brand disruption situations. Passion relationships were related to relationship strength but at a lesser extent and they did not appear to involve issues of partner quality. It would seem that due to a weaker bond these relationships are more susceptible to tendencies of non-repurchase after brand disruptions occur.

KEYWORDS *brand disruption, business continuity, consumer-brand relationships, interpersonal relationship theory, relationship strength*

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Earlier research has clearly demonstrated that loyalty can promote a unique bond between consumers and specific products or companies (Jacoby & Chestnut, 1978). As such, the use of a relational approach may provide a better, and broader, understanding of the bond that develops between customers and brands (Fournier & Yao, 1996). In 1998, Fournier postulated that brand is a partner in a dyadic relationship with the consumer and highlighted the holistic character of the phenomena. More recently Aaker, Fournier, & Brasel (2004) building on the earlier work of Fournier, developed a model to explain consumer-brand relationships based on the appreciation that acts of transgression and brand personality have a prominent role in the relationship strength formation. Investigations into brands has led to sufficient evidence to support that, when investigating the broader aspects of the consumer-brand relationship, it is necessary to adopt a more holistic and relational perspective (Keller, 2003).

An appreciation of the strength of the bond and how that bond may be broken is particularly important in light of recent catastrophic events such as the 2010 BP oil spill off the American coast and Toyota brake failures worldwide. These events serve as reminders that what appears to be strong connections between consumers and company/product brands may actually be built on fragile relationship bonds. It is highly likely that how the brand relationship is developed will affect whether it will withstand short-term disruptions. Decisions concerning whether to maintain a brand relationship, repurchase, or switch brands may often be more emotional/behavioral than based on facts. One's experience with a brand affects the satisfaction and loyalty toward that brand directly and indirectly through brand personality associations (Brakus, Schmitt, & Zarantonello, 2009). In line with this observation it was determined that the congruence between brand personality and self-image increases not only consumer satisfaction but also the consumer-brand relationship. It is interesting to note that research has indicated that for high involvement products the consumer-brand relationship quality mediates the effect of satisfaction on consumers' brand loyalties, but for low involvement products satisfaction directly influences brand loyalty (Park & Ewha, 2005).

Outcomes of the work of Fournier (1998) and Aaker (1997) suggested that brand personality significantly influences relationship strength and can help in predicting the strength of consumer-brand relationships. They tested the effects of two contrasting brand personalities, Sincerity and Excitement (Aaker, 1997) as these two classes of relationships were reported to be related to different brand personalities. These relied on the constructs of the two ideals of intimate relationships: Intimacy-Loyalty and Passion (Fletcher, Simpson, Thomas, & Giles, 1999) respectively.

Sheth and Patvatiyar (2002) have argued that companies attempt to promote relationships with consumer partners to insulate them from market whims. Price and Arnould, (1999) note that such activities are of particular

importance in the service sector due to the intangible and inseparable nature of services. Bansal, Irving, and Taylor, (2004) and Aaker, Fournier, and Brasel (2004) noted a research gap in the brand literature relating to the type of bonds different consumers establish with distinct brand personalities, as well as the relevant relationship patterns that can affect consumer-brand interactions. Concerned by this gap in the literature the objective of the research was to explore the extent to which different consumer-brand relationships are related to the quality or the strength of the bonds that consumers develop with brands as well as the underlying strength of that relationship. It was felt that such information would provide insights into what firms might consider when seeking to position a brand for both its ability to connect the consumer to the product as well as its ability to withstand incidences of brand disruption.

CONCEPTUAL MODEL AND HYPOTHESES OF STUDY

A premise of the study was that the Relationship Ideal Scale (RIS) of Fletcher et al. (1999) is applicable to the brand relationships context (Nobre, 2010). This instrument is the result of research on intimate relationships and the Relationship Ideas model can be explained by the two basic factors of Intimacy-Loyalty and Passion. The ideal relationship of Intimacy-Loyalty can be characterized with adjectives such as: caring, respectful, honest, trusting, and support. The ideal relationship of Passion can be characterized with adjectives such as: exciting, fun, and independent.

Expanding on the prior research the authors developed a conceptual model based on the hypothesis that specific consumer-brand relationships should influence the quality or the strength of the bonds that consumers develop with brands.

Aaker et al. (2004), building on an earlier work (Aaker, 1997), attempted to explain consumer-brand relationships by testing the effects of the two opposing brand personalities of Sincerity and Excitement. They concluded that (1) sincere brands tend to facilitate strong and stable relationships based on trust but they are more susceptible to the transgression effects that may be irreversible. They also noted that (2) the brands of excitement tended to nurture less stable relationships but that customers are more benevolent with their transgression acts and the reparation of problems may actually serve to reinforce the relationship. From this research two classes of relationships were identified that relied on the constructs of the two observed ideals of intimate relationships. The two classes are Intimacy-Loyalty (Fletcher et al., 1999) and Passion (Nobre, 2010).

Aaker's (Aaker et Al., 2004) study suggests that brand personality influences the Relationship Strength and may predict the type of consumer-brand relationship that will be formed. Brand personality is, in fact, one potential

source of relationship expectations (Aggarwal, 2004) and those expectations that relate to Partner Quality (Altman & Taylor, 1973) are instrumental in the type of relationship that will develop over time. From an interpersonal-relationship theory perspective individuals adjust relationships according to the perceptions of the Partner Quality in accord with their own desires and expectations (Fletcher & Simpson, 2000). The Partner Quality interactions have the purpose of defining the belief the customer has in his or her relationship with the brand. This is particularly relevant to such relationships as Intimacy-Loyalty since they are based on long-term mutual benefits such as trust and honesty. Therefore, Partner Quality is considered as a mediating variable between the consumer-brand relationship of Intimacy-Loyalty and Relationship Strength. This construct is responsible for the development of the study's hypothesis:

- H1:** The influence of consumer-brand relationships of Intimacy-Loyalty on Relationship Strength will be mediated by the consumer perceptions of Partner Quality.

Brand relationships of Passion are characterized by less stable bonds, based on initial strong socioemotional benefits, which tend to decline over time or to evolve to a different type of a relationship (Fletcher et al., 1999). Usually, this kind of relationships inspires deep feelings on people based on faith and a strong will to be involved in the relationship. Thus, it is expectable that Passion relationships are instantly evaluated by partners as highly rewarded relationships (Nobre, 2010). This led to the second hypothesis:

- H2:** Consumer-brand relationship of Passion will be a predictor of Relationship Strength.

METHODOLOGY

Brand Selection and Participants

The study featured eight well-known brands in the Portuguese market. These brands represented different product categories, brand personalities, and functional versus symbolic usage. The utilitarian brands were Continente (stores/supermarkets) and Luso (mineral water). The symbolic brands were Chanel (fragrances) and Nike. Brands that were both symbolic and utilitarian brands were Mercedes, Volkswagen, Land Rover, and Coca-Cola.

A sample of 297 valid questionnaires was obtained. When comparing the sample to the Portuguese population it is important to note that the 2001 Census (Instituto Nacional de Estatística, 2002) gender found that there was no statistically significant difference from the Portuguese men and women division of the population (gender: $\chi^2(1) = .161$, $p = .69$). This

was consistent with the study's male/female population breakdown. The respondents were between 18 and 86 years old.

Measures

For the sake of demonstrated test reliability and cross-cultural consistency existing and tested instruments were used to measure each of the constructs studied. The construct of consumer-brand relationship was assessed by the short version of Relationship Ideals Scale (Fletcher et al., 1999). Relationship Strength and Partner Quality were measured by the Relationship Strength Indicators and Partner Quality Scale (Aaker et al., 2004).

Procedures

Participants were contacted directly by undergraduate students and non-student volunteers who distributed the questionnaire with the instructions. The participants were instructed to answer the questionnaires when alone and then to return them. Participants were not paid. Each participant answered one questionnaire for each brand he or she used (or had used). To avoid primacy and regency effects (Aaker, 1997), the order in which the consumer-brand relationship traits appeared were rotated.

Sampling

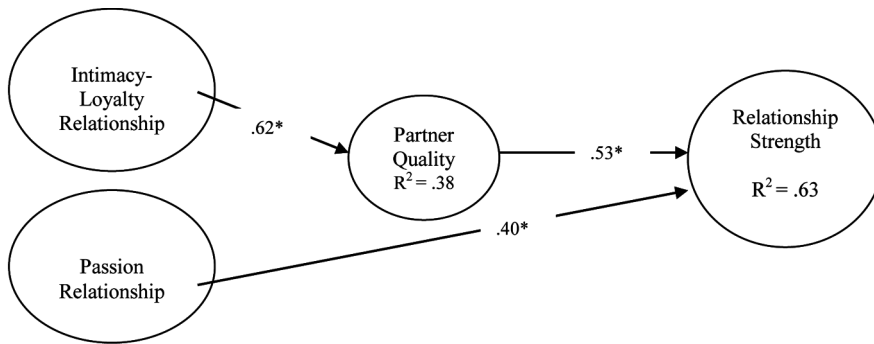
A sample of 604 consumer-brand relationships was extracted from the 297 valid questionnaires, according to the procedure used for sampling by Cronin and Taylor, (1992). About 80% of these relationships involved the brands Coca-Cola, Continente, Luso, and Nike, and the remaining 20% involved Volkswagen, Chanel, Mercedes, and Land Rover.

RESULTS

Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) and Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) were used to test the proposed theoretical framework (see Figure 1). Statistical software AMOS 17.0 (Arbuckle, 1973) for Windows 2003 was used for estimating parameters and computing goodness-of-fit measures through Full-Information Maximum Likelihood (FIML) estimator. The hypotheses were considered acceptable when a statistical level of p equal to or less than .05 existed.

Reliability

High internal consistency was achieved for each factor of consumer-brand relationship—Intimacy-Loyalty and Passion (Cronbach's alphas were .89



Note: The estimates were completely standardized. *Coefficient is significant at the .01 level (2-tailed).

FIGURE 1 Path diagram.

and .90, respectively)—and for each factor of Relationship Strength—Commitment, Intimacy, Satisfaction, and Self-Connection (Cronbach's alphas ranged from .86 to .92). Similarly, the one-dimensional scale of Partner Quality presented a Cronbach's alpha of .91.

Measurement Model

A CFA was conducted to assess the correspondence between measures and data. Each item or component was restricted to load on its pre-specified factor with the four first-order factors allowed to correlate freely. This model contained four latent variables (Intimacy-Loyalty Relationship, Passion Relationship, Relationship Strength, and Partner Quality) and 22 measures. Intimacy-Loyalty, Passion and Partner Quality are one-dimensional scales with six items each one. These items served as measures. In the case of Relationship Strength scale, the items were averaged for each one of the four components which served as indicators in the CFA. This strategy was subordinated to the minimum sample size requirements for SEM designs of a ratio of five cases for each estimated parameter (Bentler, 1989).

Results, as interpreted by the goodness-of-fit measures, indicated that the model fits the data well. The chi-square of this model was significant at the predetermined level (.001) ($\chi^2(129) = 602.6$, $p < .001$). Since the chi-square statistic is sensitive to sample size, additional fit measures (independent of sample size) were calculated. This model achieved .93, .91, .94, .94 and .93 for NFI, RFI, CFI, IFI, and TLI, respectively (values of .90 or greater are recommended for an acceptable fit); and 0.08 for RMSEA (acceptable values range from .05 to .08, according to Hair, Anderson, Tatham, & Black, 1998). Unidimensionality was evidenced by the large and significant standardized loadings of each indicator on its intended construct, with an average loading size of .83. Table 1 also shows that the variance extracted (Fornell & Larcker, 1981) was above the recommended level of .50 for all the constructs.

TABLE 1 Squared Constructs Inter correlations and Construct Extracted Variances

	Intimacy-loyalty rel.	Passion relationship	Relationship strength	Partner quality
$\rho_{vc(n)}$	.63	.70	.72	.75
Intimacy-Loyalty Rel.	1			
Passion Relationship	.49	1		
Relationship Strength	.41	.41	1	
Partner Quality	.38	.21	.51	1

$\rho_{vc(n)}$ = variance extracted (Fornell & Larcker, 1981).

Note. The squared constructs inter-correlations in cells correspond to the shared variances between constructs.

Discriminant validity was assessed in two different ways. First, a chi-square test was performed for each pair of latent constructs on a measurement model constraining their correlation to equal one and also with a baseline measurement model without this constraint. The difference between these two chi-square tests was submitted again to a chi-square test for each pair of constructs resulting in a total of 10 significant chi-square-difference tests providing evidence of discriminant validity. The shared variance was, additionally, compared among any two constructs (i.e., the square of their correlation) with their both extracted variances (i.e., average variances explained in the items by the constructs) (Fornell & Larcker, 1981; MacKenzie, Podsakoff, & Rich, 1999). Table 1 shows that all the shared variances were less than the respective extracted variances. Evidence of discriminant validity in the measures of all constructs under study was again taken for granted.

Path Analysis Model Estimates

Since the model demonstrated construct validity the path diagram was estimated. The final model achieved a good fit: Chi-square = 606.5, $df = 151$, $p < .001$, NFI = .93, RFI = .91, CFI = .94, IFI = .94, and TLI = .93, RMSEA = .08. Figure 1 shows that all the paths proposed were statistically significant.

The estimates showed that the consumer-brand relationship of Intimacy-Loyalty had a significant positive direct effect (.62, $p < .01$) on Partner Quality, and a significant indirect effect (.33, $p < .01$) on Relationship Strength through Partner Quality. In addition Partner Quality showed a direct significant positive impact (.53, $p < .01$) on Relationship Strength. Thus, results gave support to hypothesis 1. The estimates also showed that the consumer-brand relationship of Passion is a predictor of Relationship Strength (hypothesis 2). In fact, Passion Relationship had a significant positive direct effect (.40, $p < .01$) on Relationship Strength.

CONCLUSION

Recognition of the importance of brand relationships, how they are established, and factors that might influence the bond during situations of brand disruption is of increasing importance. This is highlighted with recent brand disasters, e.g., BP and Toyota (2010) as well as past incidences, e.g., P&G's Tylenol deaths (1982), lead paint problems with Chinese toys imported by Hasbro (2007), and their ensuing effects on the brand relationship. An aspect of the brand relationship was noted by Fullerton (2005) in his focus on brand commitment loyalty in what he describes as affective commitment and continuance commitment. Fullerton describes affective commitment as "rooted in shared values, identification and attachment" and continuance commitment as binding consumers to brands as a result of a difficulty "in getting out of a relationship or perceiving few alternatives outside the relationship" (Fullerton, 2005, p. 99). It seems reasonable to relate affective commitment to being similar to the personality trait in the study of Intimacy-Loyalty and continuance commitment as similar to those described as Passion relationships. Fullerton found that affective relationships were strong drivers of both repurchase and advocacy intentions toward the brand. It is not surprising that he also determined that continuance commitment was only weakly related to repurchase. Fullerton's finding notes that the type of brand relationship may be more important than the actual product satisfaction in maintaining consumer retention. Here we would note the importance in the difference in Intimacy-Loyalty and Passion-driven relationships. Consistent with Fullerton's findings, the authors found that Intimacy-Loyalty bonds served to maintain the relationship through developed partner quality while Passion bonds were to a much lesser extent associated with relationship strength. Observing that Intimacy-Loyalty relationships had a relationship in the study to quality, it is interesting to note that research has indicated that for high involvement products the consumer-brand relationship quality mediates the effect of satisfaction on consumers' brand loyalties, but for low involvement products satisfaction directly influences brand loyalty (Park & Ewha, 2005).

Jones and Sasser (1995) built on this observation and suggest that it is the type of bond that is important and not actually consumer satisfaction. They believe that this may be why satisfaction is, at times, a poor predictor of customer retention. Adding a psychological dimension, Sternberg (1997) views intimacy, passion, and decision/commitment as the three elements of the foundation of love. He states that intimacy relates to closeness and bonding, which is different from passion, which he views related to physical attraction and sexual desire. Such descriptions make intuitive sense when, for example, considering the difference between developing a bond with a pharmaceutical product (Johnson and Johnson's approach) and a woman's

cologne (Chanel) or “fashion” auto (Porsche). It seems relevant to project this perspective into the brand environment that would correspond to the manner in which the authors differentiate intimacy and passion. Kjikic and Oatley (2004) extend this concept and add that these relationships are supposed to add meaning and sense to our lives. Fournier (1998) suggests that if an object is to be “loved” it must be personified in some manner so as to be able to be perceived as an active partner in the relationship and able to reciprocate in the emotional bond.

One might argue that in an intimacy-loyalty brand relationship the brand adds value to the consumer through partner quality in a manner similar to the way that loyalty adds value to the personal relationship. It provides a type of psychological glue that secures the bond between partners. It is this glue that serves to secure relationships, whether personal or brand, when difficulties arise.

Fullerton states, “In order for brand evaluations to lead to loyalty related behaviours, commitment (and affective commitment in particular) must also be created by the experience” (2005, p 108). The results of this study seem to support the author’s finding that Intimacy-Loyalty bonds have a higher association with relationship strength than Passion bonds. It would seem that Passion bonds would create a heightened sense of excitement and “in the minute” product support. If, however, a disruption in that passion were to occur (due for example to product disappointment or a new passion was developed for another brand) that repurchase could be questionable. Saab might serve as an example of this as the auto maker had a long-standing passion relationship with its consumers until General Motors took over the brand and reduced quality. The result was a consumer switch to other brands of similar passion such as BMW and Audi. Under Intimacy-Loyalty, however, the nature of the bond could be considered more mature/stable and thus would be more secure under situational adverse brand conditions to a better extent than relationships that have focused on passion. It is interesting to note that in view of Toyota’s severe brake problem resulting in deaths (in 2009/2010) consumers tended to repeat purchase and remain loyal.

Beverland, Chung, and Kates (2009) report that in situations where a service firm committed a breach of trust through some form of transgression, consumers with high levels of emotional involvement were more likely to remain within the relationship because they became involved in some level of emotional processing that resulted in their placing the problem in a broader relationship context. When considering whether trust and intimacy can be developed within the brand environment, the work of Guese and Haelg (2008) is relevant as they demonstrated that intimacy could be developed and such development increased brand trust and brand partner quality. In line with the work of Guese, similar to personal relationships, physical and psychological injuries were determined to be two main categories for one’s “love” toward a brand to weaken or even vanish (Hemetsberger, Kittinger-Rosanelli, & Friedmann, 2009).

This study emphasizes the role of the consumer-brand relationship in understanding multi-brand, symbolic consumption. In addition, the study's results offer a more holistic perspective in the understanding of the construct brand personality. While brand personality has been significantly studied and developed in literature with wide applications in brand management, the notion of consumer-brand relationship has lacked direct practical implementation. One contribution of the study was to promote the understanding of how a brand relationship such as passion can stimulate sales but a relationship such as Intimacy-Loyalty can contribute to business continuity during times of product brand disruptions.

As previously demonstrated, the results supported the hypotheses of the study. Consumer-brand relationship was shown to be an important predictor of relationship strength. Brand relationships of Intimacy-Loyalty seemed to influence the strength of the ties consumers establish with brands in an indirect way through the inferences they make about the quality of the brand as a partner. Passion relationships, however, tend to be favorably evaluated by customers and customers tend to be more excited with those brands. Of importance is that the study is not limited to attitudinal aspects. The behavioral component of brand relationships was captured by relationship strength through the commitment variable. This variable contains items reflecting operational investments in committed and lasting relationships and can be considered behavioral indicators of loyalty (Grundlach, Achrol, & Mentzer, 1995). This is directly relevant to how a firm should position a brand's relationship with the understanding that factors such as passion, which may have immediate sales consequences, may not be able to sustain consumers should brand disruptions occur in the manner that products positioned around aspects of brand intimacy and loyalty might.

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